

Omnidrive

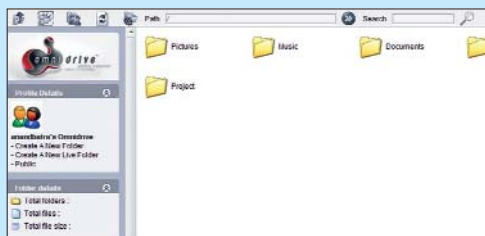
Currently in private beta, Omnidrive (www.omnidrive.com) is not offering accounts to the public. However, as of this writing, you can request an invite if you want to try out their service. Understandably, there is no information at the site about price plans—yet.

This is another service that provides cross-platform support with desktop clients for both Windows and Mac. Also, we encountered no significant issues while accessing their service from browsers on both platforms—quite surprising for a product currently in private beta.

The desktop client integrates with My Computer under Windows. You can copy files over to this folder, and your files will automatically be uploaded. It also synchronises with the remote server, updating files and folders as required. You can also access your account from a Web interface. Here you can upload files, share your files with other users, create new folders, edit your account settings, and customise the interface. The Web interface of Omnidrive is clean and resembles Windows Explorer.

Omnidrive offers more features than any other free solution does. Key features include drag and drop support, RSS feeds for users to keep track of the files you upload, file tagging, public and private sharing, developer integration through APIs and permanent URLs for files. With permanent URLs, others can access your files anytime, anywhere. You get encrypted storage and secure communication over SSL.

The Omnidrive Blog is where you get to read about the latest news and details about the service. They offer a set of FAQs and e-mail support for users. The site mentions that user forums and a re-vamped support centre is coming soon.



The Omnidrive Interface

you'll get more information about what's going on with Openomy. You can read the status of their service at <http://openomystatus.blogspot.com>

Openomy offers their API to developers so they can integrate their services into the applications they develop. The API documentation is comprehensive and well-structured.

Having a simple, traditional interface can be an advantage, especially with browser and cross-platform compatibility. However, the lack of features such as drag and drop, the use of AJAX, and an iconic interface are an obvious disadvantage when compared to services like Box.net. However, there is support for tagging and RSS feeds. The file upload process is another area where Openomy loses out: you don't get details about the amount of data uploaded, the upload speed, and so on.

You get support via e-mail, a set of FAQs, and via their blog.



The Openomy file manager

Streamload

Having featured in Time Magazine's list of the 50 "coolest" Web sites, Streamload (www.streamload.com) is an online storage service of note. You get a 25 GB account free upon signup, with a 100 MB/month bandwidth cap. Paid accounts have unlimited storage but limited bandwidth. For instance, for \$4.95 (Rs 225) per month, you get 2 GB/month bandwidth, and for \$9.95 (Rs 450), you get 25 GB/month. The bandwidth limitation explains the "unlimited storage"!

Streamload's desktop client is available only for Windows. However, we had no issues accessing Streamload with any browser.

The interface is simple, and drag-and-drop support is well implemented. You can upload files using the desktop client (if you're running Windows) and also via the Web interface, which offers options for single file uploading, batch uploading, video and photo sharing, and you can use the TV and Movie Locker (a fancy name for the feature for uploading videos). They call their service "the largest online media center."

Streamload, too, misses out on features such as AJAX implementation, RSS feeds, and sharing. However, one advantage is that you get permanent URLs for your files. Support is in the form of a set of FAQs, tutorials, and help via e-mail.



The Streamload file manager is quite nifty

If Streamload is to compete with top-level service providers, they'll have to take a hard look at the price plans, which offer unlimited storage on the one hand and limit the bandwidth to low levels on another.

In Conclusion

The six services we've reviewed were close to each other in terms of features offered as well as price plans. While .Mac stands out for offering Web hosting along with online storage, Jungle Disk offers the best value for money due to their pay-as-you-use model. Box.net offers the best Web-based interface, and Openomy offers the simplest interface of all. Omnidrive (see box *Omnidrive*) is excellent, considering its early stage of development; the feature set is very impressive. Streamload loses out on cross-platform support.

Overall, we think .Mac is the best of the lot. Omnidrive seems to us a strong contender for top spot, but it's in private beta as of now, like we've mentioned. If JungleDisk decides to incorporate a Web-based interface in the future, it will probably share top spot with .Mac. ■

readersletters@jasubhai.com